willingness, Komer later highlighted another risk of the lack of a formal commitment or at least "prior preparations" that allies regularly undertook: the danger that the US would have been unable to help in time.[272] Furthermore, one can ask what Nehru would have done had the US made its assistance contingent on an alliance. Finally, one can wonder if an alliance would have deterred a Chinese attack.

Nehru has been credited with successfully "avoid[ing] entering into an alliance."[273] There were indeed calls in India to ally with the US.[274] However, there were few, if any, such calls from Washington. Even before the war there had been little expectation in the Kennedy administration that India would join an alliance and little desire that it should do so. Kennedy accepted that India would remain nonaligned, noting, like Eisenhower, that the US, too, had taken a neutral position in the early years of its independence. Bowles had also told Nehru that the US did not believe that Delhi would ever agree to a "formal alliance" with the US. Intelligence assessments had further noted that India was unlikely to give up nonalignment. The State Department Near East and South Asia bureau had expected India to continue to stand "sometimes on the side of the Bloc, sometimes on our side and always on its own side."[275]

Once the war was underway, Kaysen expected a rethinking in India, but noted to Kennedy, "Our military assistance is designed to help a friend, not win an ally.… We can expect the Indians to redefine their nonalignment policy, but we do not expect India to abandon this policy." The then State Department intelligence bureau director later noted that the US understood the reasons India would maintain "good relations" with the Soviet Union. Kaysen indeed outlined at least three of them: aid, MiGs, and a UN veto.[276]

For the US, more allies would mean more burdens. Rusk had stressed to Galbraith in 1961, "We are not reaching out for additional allies." During the war, even the ambassador became concerned about the prospect: "The Indians are busy worrying about the end of non-alignment. It is we that should be doing the worrying on this."[277] Rusk indeed was shocked at Nehru's request of November 19 and wanted to ensure that the prime minister realized the implications of his letters, which "in effect propose[d] not only a military alliance between India and the United States but complete commitment by us to a fighting war … a proposal which cannot be reconciled with any further pretense of non-alignment. If this is what